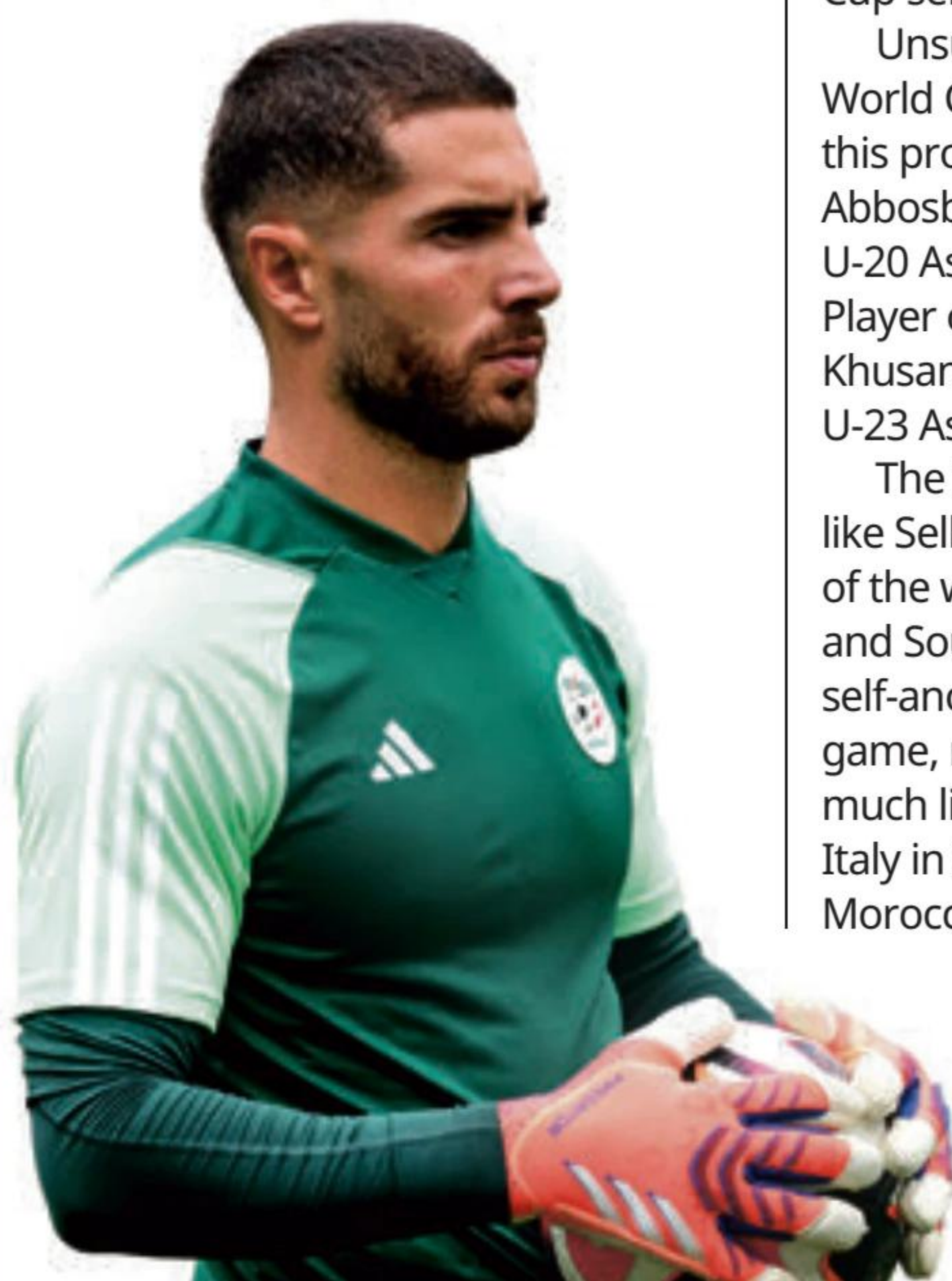


Luca Zidane (**below**), son of France's 1998 World Cup hero Zinedine Zidane, chose to represent Algeria, which qualified for the World Cup after a decade — after he could not break into a deep French squad comprising Mike Maignan and Luke Chevalier.

Another major consequence of a larger pool of teams is that it leaves the door open for a fresh set of ideas — be it Jordan's fluid changes in formation or Uzbekistan's astute youth development infrastructure.

Jordan's change in manager —



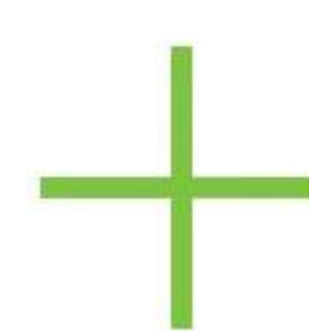
from Hussein Ammouta to Jamal Sellami — shifted the team's shape to a counter-attacking 3-4-2-1 in the World Cup qualifiers, transforming it from a composed low-block side to one firing on all cylinders. The architect, Sellami, and the result: 16 goals in six matches and a direct World Cup qualification.

Uzbekistan, on the other hand, worked on building strong age-group teams, winning the U-20 Asian Cup (2023), consecutive U-23 Asian Cup finals (2022, 2024), an Olympic bronze medal, and reaching the U-17 Asian Cup semifinal in 2023.

Unsurprisingly, the success in the World Cup qualification came through this proven assembly line, including Abbosbek Fayzullaev, the 2023 AFC U-20 Asian Cup MVP and AFC Youth Player of the Year, and Abdukodir Khusanov, a U-20 Asian champion and U-23 Asian Cup runner-up.

The impressive show of coaches like Sellami from unassuming corners of the world is bound to make Europe and South America, the long self-anointed gatekeepers of the game, rethink old assumptions — much like South Korea's upset against Italy in 2002, or Walid Regragui's Morocco against Portugal in 2022.

The beautiful game has always promised universality. Next year, with its most inclusive canvas yet, the FIFA World Cup will finally deliver it.



Global representation

QUALIFIED

Europe

Austria, Belgium, Croatia, France, Germany, Netherlands, Norway, Portugal, Scotland, Spain, Switzerland, England

South America

Argentina, Brazil, Colombia, Ecuador, Paraguay, Uruguay

North America

Canada, Curacao, Haiti, Mexico, Panama, United States of America

Africa

Algeria, Cape Verde, Egypt, Ghana, Ivory Coast, Morocco, Senegal, South Africa, Tunisia

Asia

Australia, Iran, Japan, Jordan, Qatar, Saudi Arabia, South Korea, Uzbekistan

Oceania

New Zealand

CAN QUALIFY

Europe

Albania, Bosnia and Herzegovina, Czechia, Denmark, Ireland, Italy, Kosovo, Northern Ireland, North Macedonia, Poland, Romania, Slovakia, Sweden, Turkey, Ukraine, Wales

South America

Bolivia, Suriname

North America

Jamaica

Africa

Democratic Republic of the Congo

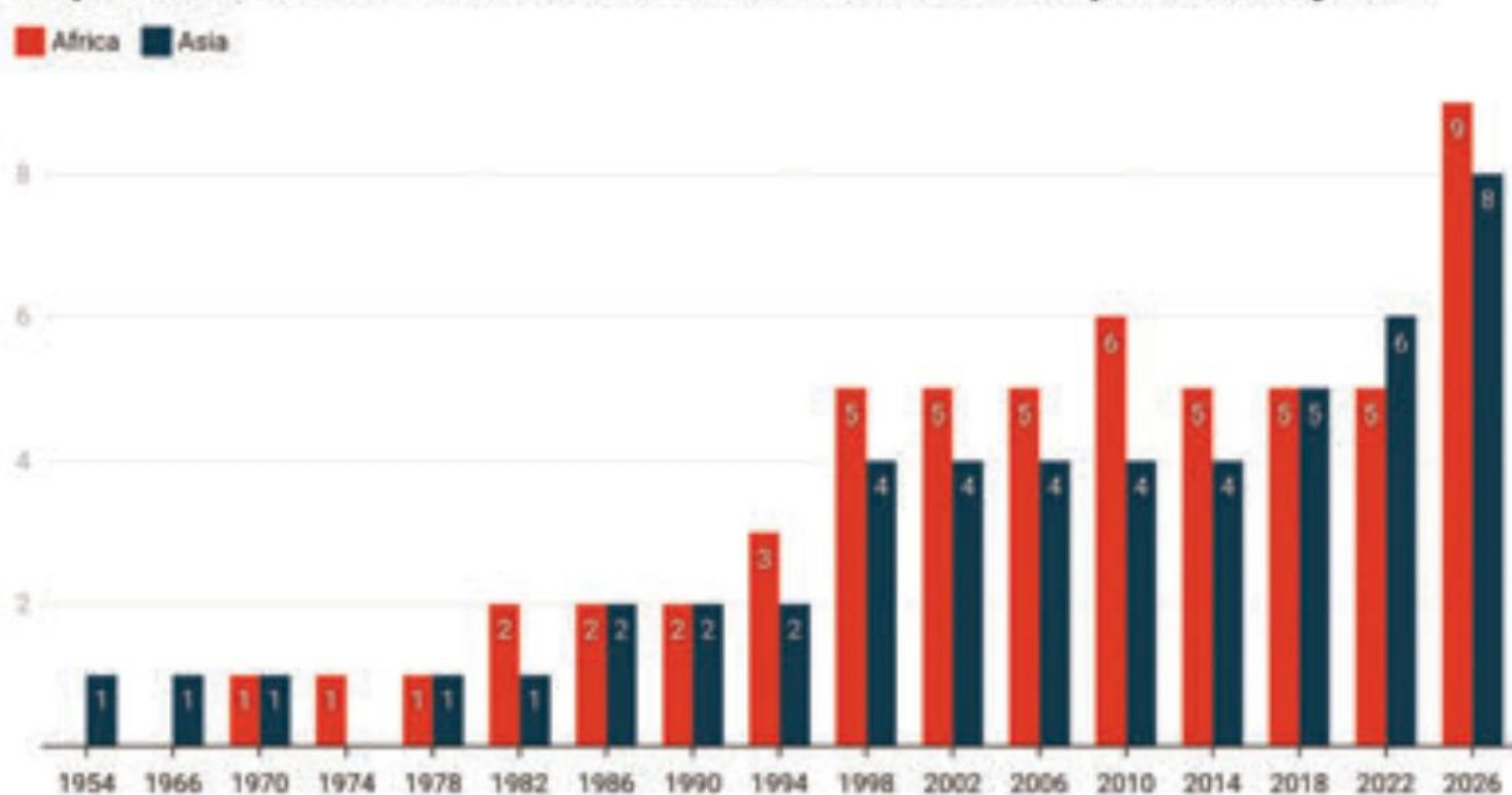
Asia

Iraq

Oceania

New Caledonia

Representation of Asia and Africa in FIFA World Cup over the years



*The first FIFA World Cup to have representation from Asia or Africa was in 1954